

Communication

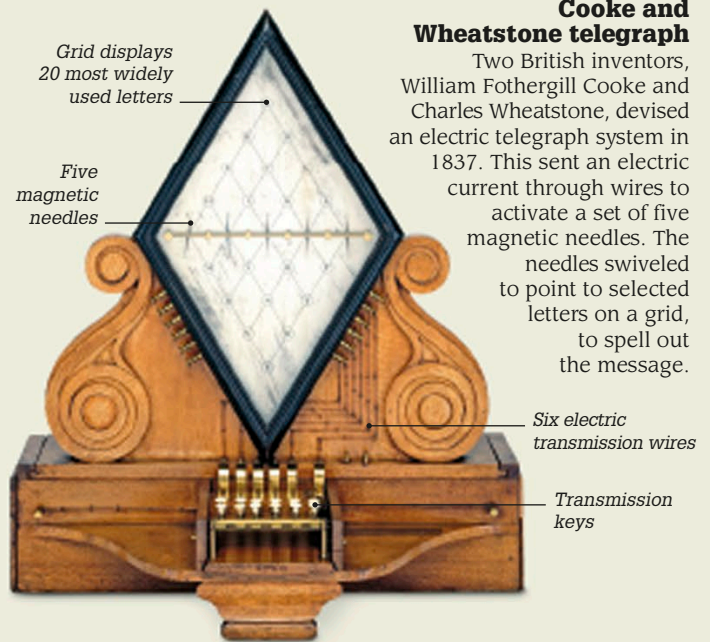
In past centuries, long-distance communication between people was a slow process. Letters, carried on horseback or by ship, could take days or even weeks to reach their destination. Things speeded up with the invention of the telegraph, which sent a message along an electric wire instantaneously. The telephone, radio, and television soon followed. Today, using computers and handheld devices, we can make instant contact with each other almost anywhere in the world.



Pony Express riders carried the mail in leather pouches on their saddlebags.

Carrying the mail

The Pony Express, which began operating in 1860, delivered mail from Missouri in the midwest to California in the west, a hazardous journey of nearly 2,000 miles (3,000 km). Using a relay system, with lightning changes of horses and riders, the high-speed service cut at least 10 days off the time taken by rival mail companies. The coming of the telegraph saw the end of the Pony Express in 1861.



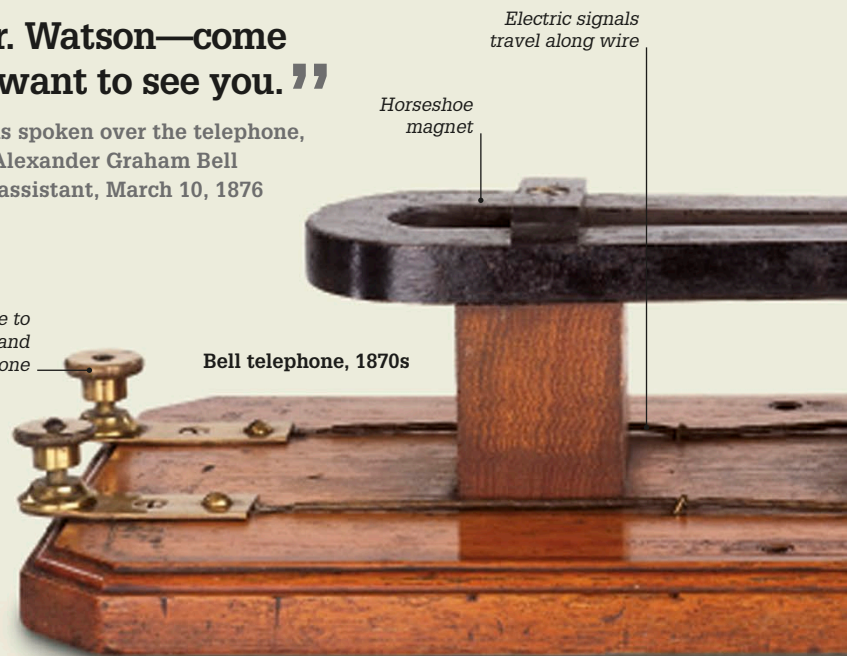
Cooke and Wheatstone telegraph

Two British inventors, William Fothergill Cooke and Charles Wheatstone, devised an electric telegraph system in 1837. This sent an electric current through wires to activate a set of five magnetic needles. The needles swiveled to point to selected letters on a grid, to spell out the message.

“Mr. Watson—come here—I want to see you.”

First words spoken over the telephone, by Alexander Graham Bell to his assistant, March 10, 1876

Wires attach here to take signals to and from the telephone



Bell telephone, 1870s

Key events

1844

American inventor Samuel Morse gave a public demonstration of his telegraph system when he sent a message down a wire from Washington D.C. to Baltimore, MD.

1858

The first undersea transatlantic cable came into service, linking Europe and North America by telegraph. It ran from Ireland to Newfoundland, Canada.

1876

Alexander Graham Bell designed the first working telephone, which could transmit and receive human speech.

1886

Heinrich Hertz detected the existence of radio waves, first theorized by James Clerk Maxwell. This discovery paved the way for future research into wireless radio communication.

Alexander Graham Bell

